

LADIES IN BLUE

The Minoan civilization was named after the legendary King Minos, whose supposed palace of Knossos on the island of Crete was excavated by British archaeologist Arthur Evans at the turn of the 20th century. Among the discoveries at Knossos were the fragments of dynamic frescoes depicting sporting events and also various scenes portraying both men and women taking part in everyday life.

With their oiled, ringleted hair and open-fronted, tight-waisted bodices, the three Minoan ladies display the styles peculiar to their culture. Their hairdressed locks are draped with beads and caught in with metal fillets. They wear delicate bracelets and hold the bodice tops together with more accessories. The modern restoration highlights the complex woven textiles Crete was famous for.

Little of the original paintings has survived. In the 1920s Evans employed Dutch architect and artist Piet de Jong to assemble the fragments, and reconstitute the rest. At that time illustrators of chic fashion journals were setting models against backdrops of Mediterranean resorts, and stylized folk embroidery was influencing textile patterns. The restoration of the frescoes was criticized – perhaps with some justification – for being over-influenced by current fashion tastes.

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It is impossible to disregard the suspicion that their painters have tempered their zeal for accurate reconstruction with a somewhat inappropriate predilection for covers of *Vogue*.

EVELYN WAUGH, 1920s

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◀ WALL PAINTING, KNOSSOS, C.1600_{BCE}

These ladies of the Minoan court display their wealth with elaborate necklaces, bracelets, and hair ornaments.

